Punto fermo

A trestle table in solid walnut, with one stone in the joint

Punto fermo is a dining table for eight in solid noce canaletta, built as the oldest form of the type: boards resting on trestles. Medieval tables were not fixed: they were set up and taken away (Viollet-le-Duc, 1873). Modern furniture fixes the top and then fights its movement with hardware. Punto fermo goes back to the unfixed top, with workshop precision.

Concept. Solid wood moves: a metre of walnut changes about 14 mm in width between seasons, while stone does not move at all. The table is built on that difference: wood moves and comes apart; the only fixed point is the stone where it locks. Six loose boards (2400 × 164 × 40 mm) are each pinned on their axis by an ash dowel and locked by an ash wedge driven through the trestle head, so every board moves on its own and the joint between boards shows the season: 0.8 mm when the air is humid, 4.8 mm when it is dry. Loose ash splines under each joint keep the boards level and close the gap below.

The fixed point. The stretcher's through-tenon passes through the trestle post and through a collar of Nero Sahara Noir marble; a tapered ash key, set with a mallet, presses the stone against the post. The stone works only in compression (0.08 MPa), never glued and never in bending, with 1 mm of clearance per side. It is not a luxury placed next to the wood but the place where the wood is held. Bertonio's Aymara dictionary (1612) has a word for it, *chhakhua*: the stone driven into the wall to tie the roof poles to it, and also the poles tied to it: the whole joint.

Making and use. 48 parts, no metal hardware, one mallet. No part weighs more than 16 kg (a glued trestle): the table travels flat and is assembled in seven steps. A damaged board is replaced without dismantling the table: two wedges out, the spline slides out through the end, the board lifts away. Beyond the key, the end grain of the tenon stays visible and shows its rings.

Materials and finishes. Noce canaletta for boards, trestles and stretcher; frassino for dowels, wedges, splines and keys; Nero Sahara Noir, honed, with 3 mm chamfers: three materials of the Porada collection, each doing the job it does best. Walnut and ash are oiled, so the surface remains something to touch.

Method. Each claim was checked against a source or a calculation whose threshold was written down before computing. The stone cannot be a beam (9.9 MPa against 2.3 allowed); its weight neither steadies nor locks the frame; every joint was checked part by part for clashes.